

SIGCHI Social Impact Award: Asking Better Questions

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ABSTRACT

I remember when I started my DPhil studies joking with friends that my research was improving the sum total of human happiness – by one. I was enjoying the work. It was as a post-doc, however, that I began to see how knowledge, or at the very least the pursuit of knowledge, is not neutral. The things that we choose to study, the problems that we choose to focus on, and the way we frame our questions, lead towards different benefits for different interests. If we want to make a better world, then perhaps we should focus on asking better questions.

One question that was a turning point for me was posed by Steve Walker in 2002. In a world where e-commerce and e-government already had thriving, well-financed research communities, he convened a workshop asking “Can there be a Social Movement Informatics?” The topics ranged from designing with voluntary organizations and trade-unions, to investigating hate speech in Internet bulletin boards and chat rooms. Together with colleagues, we ran projects around “Design for Civil Society”, and “Technology and Social Action”, exploring how we as technologists, designers and researchers can connect and collaborate more effectively with groups promoting social change.

Following on from that work, I won an opportunity to explore how participatory approaches in international social and economic development relate to understandings of participatory design in HCI. Working with the Sironj Crop Producers Company Ltd (a co-operative of small and marginal farmers in Madhya Pradesh, India) and Safal Solutions (a small software house focused on rural development, based in Telengana, India), this was my first attempt to apply participatory design methods in a context with very limited infrastructure and resources. How can we facilitate meaningful communications about priorities and possibilities across wide social, cultural, geographical, linguistic, experiential and economic divides? How does the way we arrange, organize and conduct projects aiming to advance ‘development’ affect the outputs, the outcomes and the impacts that are achieved? How can agency, creativity and control be shared in ways that move systems towards a more just world?

I don’t know all the answers to those questions, but I have learned that the inequalities of this world are far greater than I had originally imagined. I started with high hopes that expertise in participatory design, together with a commitment to participatory development would deliver radical results. I discovered that true participation

and reciprocity is tougher than I thought. We cannot communicate effectively across such huge social divides without questioning, acknowledging and responding to our own positionality in the wider context. For example, we should ask how our own actions are contributing to harming others, such as the millions who will become, or are already, climate refugees? A few short-term “bungee research” visits will not lead us to real understanding. When key decision making remains in the usual centers of power, that simply reinforces the neo-colonial arrangements that underpin the marginalization that we say we want to change.

To create a future for humanity as part of life on this planet, we must see changes in behavior close to centers of power – and that includes ourselves. We are already enmeshed in a system of unjust socio-economic relationships. “The problem” is not something that is “out there”, it is also “in here” and all around us. Are we asking the questions that really matter?

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing**; • **Interaction design**; • **Interaction design process and methods**; • **Participatory design**; • **Social and professional topics**; • **Professional topics**; • **Computing profession**; • **Codes of ethics**; • **Software and its engineering**; • **Software creation and management**; • **Software development process management**; • **Software development methods**;

KEYWORDS

HCI4D, ICTD, ICTDEthics

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1 SPEAKER’S BIO

Andy Dearden is Emeritus Professor of Interactive Systems Design at Sheffield Hallam University. His research examines the roles of interaction designers, software engineers and technology researchers to explore how we might contribute to creating more socially just and sustainable futures for our shared human society and for our planet.

In the UK he has led multiple initiatives building networks to connect researchers, designers, social activists, public bodies and voluntary organizations. He has led research on: “Designing for Civil Society”, “Technology and Social Action”, “Securing the value of Co-Design for the 3rd Sector”, and “User Centred Healthcare Design”. His research approach combines: action research doing participatory design, organizing projects and building software; with inquiries into the roles, relationships, values and the ethics that we adopt in research for change.

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Since 2005 he has extended this focus to research applications of interaction design in the context of international social and economic development. He facilitated the first CHI workshop on “User Centered Design and International Development” in 2007, and began asking questions about the “Ethics, roles and relationships in interaction design in developing regions”. The Kheti project which he led in partnership with farmers in Sironj, Madhya Pradesh, India, received a 2009 Manthan Award for e-Enterprise and Livelihood. He recently facilitated the development of “Minimum Ethical Standards in ICTD/ICT4D Research” that are being widely adopted in the field.

Since (semi) retirement he has joined his local parish council, has stood as a Green Party candidate for his city council, and is pursuing his interest in cutting the carbon footprint of, and widening access to, academic conferences. After demonstrating the potential of hybrid (virtual & face to face) events in 2015 in a distributed multi-center workshop on “Researching for Change in a Globalising Asymmetric World”, he is currently a Remote Participation co-chair for the PDC 2022 conference.